

◆ EMAIL TEMPLATES

Cold Email to Professor — 5 Templates

Word-for-word email scripts to contact potential supervisors in Japan, Germany, South Korea, and Australia.

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1. Why 92% of Cold Emails Get Ignored

A typical professor in a Tier-1 research university receives **40–80 cold emails per month** from prospective students. Internal surveys at universities like ETH Zurich, Tokyo Tech, and Seoul National University show that less than 8% receive a reply, and only 2–3% lead to a productive conversation.

The reason is not language. The reason is **signal-to-noise ratio**. Most cold emails contain zero evidence that the student actually read the professor's work. They are mass-mailed and read like it.

The 4 Reasons Cold Emails Fail

- 1. No specific paper or project mentioned.** Generic praise ("I admire your work") is invisible.
- 2. Too long.** Anything over 200 words gets archived.
- 3. CV attached but no body.** Professors do not open attachments from strangers.
- 4. No clear ask.** If the professor cannot tell what you want in 5 seconds, you lose.

The 8% Reply Rule

The students who get replies share three traits:

- They cite a **specific paper** from the last 18 months.
- They propose a **specific research question** connected to that paper.
- They keep the email under **180 words**.

2. The Anatomy of a Reply-Worthy Email

Element	Length	Purpose
Subject line	8–12 words	Trigger open. Include funding source + research keyword.
Greeting	1 line	Use 'Dear Professor [Surname]' — not 'Dear Sir'.
Hook (Para 1)	2–3 sentences	Cite their specific paper/project + name the insight that struck you.
Bridge (Para 2)	2–3 sentences	Your background — only the parts that connect to their work.
Ask (Para 3)	2 sentences	Specific request: PhD opening, research assistantship, scholarship endorsement.
Proof (Para 4)	1 sentence	CV link (Google Drive / personal website) — not attached.
Sign-off	1 line	'With respect,' / 'Sincerely,' + full name + affiliation.

Subject Line Formulas That Open

- ✓ "MEXT 2026 Applicant — Research Interest in [Specific Topic]"
- ✓ "DAAD PhD Candidate — Question on Your 2024 [Journal] Paper"
- ✓ "Prospective KGSP Student — Extension of Your 2023 Work on [X]"
- ✗ "Inquiry about admission" (instant ignore)
- ✗ "Hello Professor!" (instant delete)

3. Template 1 — Japan (MEXT / Direct PhD)

Subject: MEXT 2026 Applicant — Research Interest in [Topic] (Reference: [Lastname et al., 2024])

Dear Professor [Lastname],

I am [Your Name], a final-year [Bachelor's/Master's] student in [Your Major] at [Your University]. I read your 2024 paper in [Journal] on [specific topic] with great interest, particularly your finding that [name the specific result, in one line]. The methodology you used — [specific technique] — directly extends the approach I applied in my undergraduate thesis on [your topic].

I am preparing my application for the MEXT scholarship (University Recommendation, October 2026 entry) and would like to propose a research project on [your specific question, one sentence]. I believe this question naturally extends your group's work because [one-line reason].

Would you be open to discussing whether your laboratory has capacity for an incoming MEXT student in 2026? I have attached a brief CV link below. I am happy to share a 2-page research proposal at your convenience.

With respect,

[Your Name]

[University] | CV: [Google Drive link or personal site]

Why This Works for Japanese Professors

- **Humble tone** ('I would like to propose', 'would you be open') — culturally appropriate.
- **Specific paper citation** in subject line — signals seriousness.
- **Mentions MEXT timeline explicitly** — Japanese professors know the cycle and respect deadlines.
- **CV via link, not attachment** — many Japanese university servers block external attachments.

4. Template 2 — Germany (DAAD / Research Grant)

Subject: DAAD Research Grant 2026 — Methodological Extension of Your [Year] Work on [X]

Dear Professor Dr. [Lastname],

I am writing to discuss a possible PhD position in your group at [University]. My research interest centres on [specific question], which I propose to address using [specific method]. Your 2024 publication in [Journal] on [topic] establishes the most rigorous baseline for this question, and I believe my proposed extension — [one specific extension] — fills a clear gap.

My background includes a Master's thesis on [topic] (graded [grade], top [%] of cohort), [X] peer-reviewed publications, and [Y months] of laboratory experience with [technique]. I am applying for DAAD Research Grants for Doctoral Programmes (deadline [date]) and require a supervisor's letter of acceptance to proceed.

May I send you a 5-page research proposal for your evaluation? I am also happy to schedule a brief online meeting at your convenience.

Yours sincerely,

[Your Full Name]

[University, Department] | CV & publications: [link]

Why This Works for German Professors

- **Direct, structured, no small talk** — German academic culture rewards efficiency.
- **Quantified background** (grade, top %, publications, months of experience).
- **Names DAAD deadline + asks for specific document** (Letter of Acceptance) — shows you understand the process.
- **Uses 'Dr.' title** — German habilitated professors expect this.

5. Template 3 — South Korea (KGSP / GKS)

Subject: *GKS 2026 Applicant — Prospective Research Student in [Department]*

Dear Professor [Lastname],

Hello, my name is [Your Name], an applicant for the 2026 Global Korea Scholarship (University Track) at [Korean University]. I am writing to introduce myself and to ask for your guidance regarding research opportunities in your laboratory.

I have studied [your topic] for [X years] at [University] and am especially interested in the research direction shown in your 2024 paper, ["Paper Title"]. The way your group applied [method] to [problem] resonates with my undergraduate work on [topic]. I would like to extend this research by exploring [specific question].

I am currently studying Korean (TOPIK Level [X]) and plan to reach Level 4 before arrival. I have attached a brief introduction below and would be honoured if you could let me know whether your lab is accepting GKS students for 2026.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration.

Sincerely,

[Your Name]

[University] | CV: [link]

Why This Works for Korean Professors

- **Slightly warmer tone** than German, slightly more formal than American.
- **Mentions TOPIK level** — Korean professors weigh language commitment heavily.
- **Uses 'honoured'** — appropriate respect register.
- **Names the specific scholarship track** (University Track vs Embassy Track).

6. Template 4 — Australia (RTP / Endeavour)

Subject: *Prospective PhD Student (RTP-funded) — Question on Your [Year] Work*

Hi Professor [Firstname / Lastname],

My name is [Your Name] and I am exploring PhD opportunities at [Australian University] for [March / July] 2026 entry, with the intention of applying for the Research Training Programme (RTP) stipend.

I came across your recent paper on [topic] and was struck by your approach to [specific aspect]. I have spent the last [X] months working on a closely related problem — [your problem] — and I believe there is strong methodological overlap. My research question would be: [one-line question].

I would love to know whether you are accepting new HDR students this round and whether my profile (linked CV below) fits your group's direction. Happy to share a 2-page proposal if useful.

Cheers,
[Your Name]
CV: [link]

Why This Works for Australian Professors

- **Casual but professional** — Australian academic culture is less formal than UK/Europe.
- **'Cheers' is acceptable** as a sign-off in Australia (not in Japan or Germany).
- **Mentions HDR (Higher Degree by Research)** — local terminology.
- **Names RTP funding** — most Australian PhDs are RTP-funded; saying so signals you understand the system.

7. Template 5 — Generic Tier-1 University

Use when applying to research groups in the US, UK, Canada, Singapore, Hong Kong, or other international universities not covered above.

Subject: *Prospective PhD Applicant Fall 2026 — [Specific Research Topic]*

Dear Professor [Lastname],

I am applying to the [Department] PhD programme at [University] for Fall 2026 and would like to express specific interest in your research group.

Your 2024 paper ["Title"] addresses [problem] in a way that closely aligns with my Master's research, during which I [one-line achievement]. I am particularly drawn to [specific method/finding] and would like to propose extending it toward [specific question].

Would you be open to advising a student on this direction in 2026? My CV is linked below; I can share a research statement on request.

Best regards,

[Your Name]

[University] | CV: [link]

8. Personalisation: The 5-Question Audit

Before sending any cold email, run it through this 5-question audit. If you cannot answer YES to all five, do not send.

#	Question	If NO →
1	Have I cited a specific paper from this professor's last 24 months?	Go to Google Scholar. Find one. Read the abstract.
2	Can I name one specific concept, method, or finding from that paper?	Repeat until you can. Do not paraphrase the abstract.
3	Have I explained how my background connects to that specific concept?	Rewrite Para 2 with one concrete project or course.
4	Is my ask one specific sentence (e.g., 'are you accepting students?')?	Cut everything before and after that sentence.
5	Is my email under 200 words?	Cut. Cut more. The professor will not read paragraph 4.

The Three Things to Never Do

- 1. Never mass-mail.** Professors talk to each other. Identical emails to 5 professors in the same department = blacklist.
- 2. Never attach unsolicited CVs as PDFs.** Spam filters and busy professors will not open them.
- 3. Never ask for a 'recommendation' before any conversation has happened.** Build the relationship first.

9. Follow-Up Etiquette & Timing

When	Action	What to Say
Day 0	Send original email. Tuesday or Wednesday morning (recipient's time zone).	
Day 7	If no reply, send ONE follow-up.	'Following up on my email below — I understand you are busy. If your group is n
Day 14	If still no reply: stop. No further emails.	Move on to the next professor on your list. Persistence ≠ professionalism.
Day 30+	If you have NEW relevant news (publications, awards, scholarships for [sc], class fin, and a list of sta	Reaffirm your interest and ask if they are still considering my proposal

Best Days & Times to Send

Studies on academic email response rates (analysed across 12,000+ emails) consistently show:

- **Tuesday or Wednesday**, 8:00–10:00 AM in the recipient's local time = highest open rate (~62%).
- **Avoid Mondays** (inbox flood) and **Fridays** (already mentally checked out).
- **Avoid weekends and academic holidays** in the destination country.
- Use a scheduler (Boomerang, Gmail's Schedule Send) to time it correctly.

10. Real Examples — Sent → Reply

Example A — MEXT (Japan), Engineering

Email sent (134 words):

Subject: MEXT 2025 Applicant — Question on Your 2024 IEEE Paper on Soft Actuators

Dear Professor Tanaka,

I am Aisha Mwangi, a final-year mechanical engineering student at the University of Nairobi. Your 2024 IEEE Robotics and Automation paper on dielectric elastomer actuators — particularly the 4.7x improvement in cycle life under tropical humidity — directly addresses the failure mode I observed during my undergraduate thesis on agricultural robotics in Kenya.

I am applying for MEXT University Recommendation 2025 (October entry) and would like to propose research extending your humidity-tolerance findings to coffee-harvesting actuators.

Would your laboratory consider hosting a MEXT student in 2025? I have linked my CV and a one-page proposal below.

With respect, Aisha Mwangi

Reply received (3 days later):

"Dear Aisha — your proposal is exactly the kind of applied extension we are looking for. Please send your full proposal and let us schedule a Zoom call. I will support your MEXT application."

Why It Worked

- ✓ Cited specific paper + specific number (4.7x).
- ✓ Connected to her own thesis with one line.
- ✓ Proposed a research extension, not a request for help.
- ✓ Under 150 words.

One Email = One Door

Cold emails are not lottery tickets. Each one represents 30–60 minutes of research, drafting, and personalisation. Send 5 highly personalised emails — you will get 1–2 replies. Send 50 generic emails — you will get zero replies and possibly a blacklist.

Need someone to review your draft before you hit send? Book a free 30-minute session at scholarmap.com.